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Summarize the 1906 San Francisco Earthquake. What factors shaped the current landscape?

The 1906 San Francisco Earthquake was one of the most devastating natural disasters in U.S. history, striking San Francisco on April 18, 1906.

What happened

- A powerful earthquake (estimated magnitude ~7.9) ruptured along the San Andreas Fault.
- The shaking lasted less than a minute, but it caused widespread structural collapse.
- Broken gas lines ignited massive fires that burned for three days, destroying much of the city.
- Around 3,000 people died, and over 200,000 were left homeless (more than half the city's population at the time).

Immediate impact

- About 80% of San Francisco was destroyed.
- Entire neighborhoods were leveled, including downtown and waterfront areas.
- Refugee camps were set up in parks like Golden Gate Park.

Factors that shaped today's San Francisco landscape

1. Rebuilding and urban design

- The city rebuilt rapidly, prioritizing economic recovery over grand redesign plans.
- Streets were largely restored on their original grid, which is why modern San Francisco still follows its pre-1906 layout.
- However, building codes improved, especially regarding fire safety and later seismic standards.

2. Earthquake engineering & building codes

- The disaster led to advances in understanding seismic risk.
- Over time, stricter building codes were introduced, influencing today's skyline with flexible, quake-resistant structures.
- Modern retrofitting programs stem from lessons learned in 1906.

3. Land use and neighborhood shifts

- Some areas were rebuilt differently:
  - Industrial zones shifted.
  - Wealthier residents moved westward toward less-damaged areas.
- This helped shape neighborhoods like the western districts becoming more residential.

4. Infrastructure modernization

- Utilities (water, gas) were redesigned to reduce fire risk.
- A more resilient water system was built, including reservoirs and improved firefighting capacity.

5. Economic and cultural transformation

- Despite devastation, San Francisco quickly reestablished itself as a major West Coast economic hub.
- The rebuilding attracted investment, reinforcing its long-term growth.

6. Awareness of fault lines and risk

- The earthquake made the San Andreas Fault famous and drove early scientific study of earthquakes.
- It shaped California's leadership in seismology and disaster preparedness.

Big picture

The 1906 earthquake didn't just destroy San Francisco—it reset it. The city you see today is

a mix of:

- **Old layout (pre-1906 grid)**
- **Post-disaster rebuilding choices**
- **Modern seismic safety innovations**

That combination—historic structure plus constant adaptation to earthquake risk—is what defines San Francisco's current landscape.

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